

New Intel 14nm fab

Intel is planning to set up a 14nm fab in the US that is rumoured to cost a whopping US 5 billion dollars

Lynx to follow Brazos

We've already seen AMD's value-oriented Fusion parts in Brazos, and it seems Lynx parts based on the 32nm Llano APU should also be arriving within the next few months

not stressing the right GPU parameters.

Not surprisingly when we come to real world CPU intensive tasks like compression/decompression and media encoding, we see the notebooks with Core i5 processors take the lead. What the benchmarks do not tell you is that for most mundane tasks, a Core i3 will get you through very easily. While not indicative of the market, the fact that all six models featured Intel processors and platforms is testament to Intel's widespread influence. Another factor that many theoretical benchmarks do not measure is the usability of the system, and the quantity of RAM. Most memory benchmarks will utilise memory only to gauge bandwidth, however, just because a system with 2 GB gives a higher bandwidth score does not mean Windows will be snappier than on a machine with 4 GB of RAM. Windows 7 is a lot less demanding on components including memory than Vista was, and thankfully, even on 2 GB these notebooks didn't slouch. The Zenith Uranium misses a point and features only 1 GB of RAM, which is glaring – even some netbooks come with 2 GB! Regardless, we continue to recommend 3 and 4 GB notebooks – as with 2 GB, Windows tends to slow down after a while, as the load on memory increases due to an increasing list of installed applications, some of which might run background tasks even when not explicitly run.

Verdict

In terms of overall performance, the **Acer Aspire 4820T** just edged out the **Acer 5742G** – mainly because of superior battery performance. The Aspire is a very different beast, with no additional graphics solution, and comes with a very handy battery and optimised power consumption. This allowed a whopping 427 minutes of backup, while playing back a VOB file – that's a shade

over 7 hours – pretty sublime, and well into netbook territory. This featured as a part of performance, and is why the Acer Aspire 4820T scores so high on the overall performance charts.

Despite not winning the Best Performance award, the **Acer 5742G** had some well-rounded scores. A good CPU, strong GPU and 3 GB of RAM, with 500 GB of storage to boot seems like a decent deal, especially for an MRP of only ₹38,990. This notebook bagged our **Editor's Pick** award, because if it's sheer computing and gaming speed you are after, the 5742G gets the nod ahead of the 4820T.



The ASUS P52F has a decent build quality but its trackpad lacks precision

Best Value?

Value can mean different things to different people. However, in our opinion, there are a few things that a notebook should have, in order for us to recommend it. Besides the spec-list, that means little for ordinary work, usability is a major element. What's the use of a really fast graphic card and quad core CPU, when the keypad is poorly designed? Or what use is a great display, when the trackpad is inaccurate? When one

reviews notebooks for a living, and uses a lot of them, one realises that on-paper specs mean as little as the on-paper capabilities of the Indian Cricket team. What matters is ability to deliver. And we try to design our tests to be indicative of not just specifications, but the look and feel factor, the usability quotient, features that may be hidden away that matter and the overall design of the product. Battery life, for example, is very important, and often neglected, but really, very important. Especially for someone who is likely to be travelling a lot, and cannot be hindered with chargers. Then there's performance – which should not be compromised for better battery life.

That being said, both the **Best Buy** and the **Best Performer** awards go to the **Acer Aspire Timeline 4820T** for a good mix of features, components, performance and frugality on power. It's stylish and upmarket looking to boot, and we reckon many an executive will find the smart grey colour in tone with the dress code for such positions. If you want something with a little more graphics power, but nearly equal on the value factor, look no further than our **Editor's Pick** – the **Acer 5742G**. Both notebooks are workhorses, and whether you want to work, play or entertain yourself – you'll not be disappointed. However, both are meant for rather different audiences. The 4820T is strictly for those on the go – it's smaller and lighter with a great battery. The Acer 5742G is the opposite – it's bulkier, heavier and thicker, and the battery life is not that great. It is meant to sit on a desk all day, and entertain you, while being plugged into the mains – this is a true desktop replacement, and the HDMI out means you can hook it up to your HDTV too.

In the end, somebody has to win, someone has to lose – and the scores tell no tall tales. However, after this mini test, we were hard pressed to find serious faults in any of the notebooks. Build quality was pretty good all round, and many of the notebooks actually looked a bit costlier than we'd have figured – which is a good thing! We're happy to report we found this year's crop of sub-₹40,000 notebooks much better than